What Is Getting Worse in New York City — and Which Agencies Are Slowing Down

NYC 311 Service Requests · Full-history analysis (Jan 2023 – Aug 2026)
Prepared from 12,951,058 cleaned records sourced live from NYC Open Data (SOCRATA `erm2-nwe9`). All figures below are computed from that dataset; none are estimates or prior-knowledge claims.

Executive Summary

New York's 311 system is carrying **more complaints every year**. Total volume rose from **3.22M (2023) → 3.46M (2024) → 3.66M (2025)**, and 2026 is on pace for roughly **3.9M** — a ~7% year-over-year climb sustained across all three comparisons (Fig 1). That headline is genuine: the reporting-channel mix is stable over the window (Web 40–48%, Phone 23–31%, Mobile 19–23%), so the growth is not an artifact of New Yorkers suddenly reporting differently.

Inside that growth, four things stand out as **operationally real and worsening**:

1. **The winter heat crisis is escalating.** Heat/Hot Water complaints are strongly seasonal, but the *winter peak itself* has more than doubled: January counts rose **30,210 (2023) → 51,325 (2024) → 67,229 (2025) → 79,928 (2026)** (Fig 3). This is not seasonality — it is a genuine, compounding trend.
2. **Residential noise and sanitation are growing at scale.** Noise-Residential is the #2 category and rose **+22%** in a full-year comparison (379k→463k). Missed Collections **+31%**, Residential Disposal **+37%**, Water System **+18%**.
3. **Infrastructure complaints are surging in 2026.** Seasonally matched (Jan–Aug 2026 vs 2025): **Damaged Trees +60%**, **Water Leak +30%**, **Plumbing +28%**, **Building/Use +33%**, **Highway Condition +92%**. These are repair-backed problems, not reporting noise.
4. **One borough is disproportionately and increasingly burdened.** The **Bronx has the highest per-capita complaint load (1.30× the city average) and the fastest-growing per-capita rate** — rising 42,629→56,804 per 100k (2023→2025, **+33%**) while Manhattan stayed roughly flat (Fig 5).

The biggest **response-time deterioration** is concentrated, not diffuse: **EDC** has effectively stopped closing complaints (median response 541h→7,891h, then 100% open in 2026); **DOHMH** and **DCWP** response times collapsed in 2026 (censoring-adjusted, both worse than the raw figures below). Meanwhile **DOB, DPR, and DCWP materially improved** across 2024–25 (Fig 6).

The single most important caveat in this report: the largest YoY volume "growth" — **Street Condition +90%** — is substantially a **reporting artifact**. It arrived as a single step-change in March 2026, driven by the "Other" (bulk/institutional) channel, not a sudden wave of resident reports (Fig 2). Treat it as a data-quality signal to investigate, not proof that streets suddenly deteriorated.

Data and Methodology

Dataset. All rows with `created_date` from **2023-01-01 to 2026-08-27** in the NYC 311 Service Requests dataset. 13,052,895 raw rows fetched and merged; 12,951,058 survive cleaning (101,837 removed as duplicate `unique_key` — a November-2023 overlap between two fetch passes; 6,913 removed from response-time metrics as implausible durations; 10 with invalid timestamps). Every removal is recorded, not silent.

How comparisons were made (important). Because the dataset now spans 3.7 years, the report uses **seasonally matched year-over-year comparisons** — e.g., *Jan–Aug 2026 vs Jan–Aug 2025* — so a winter/spring seasonal effect is not mistaken for a trend. Full-year 2024 vs 2025 comparisons are used where complete years are available. This is the methodological upgrade the earlier 8-month analysis could not make.

Response-time methodology (left-censoring). Median *response time* (hours from creation to first response) is computed **only over closed complaints**. Any complaints still open when the window ends are excluded, which biases recent-window medians *downward* (toward faster). The share of complaints still open rises sharply toward the present — from **~0.4–2%** for 2023–2025 months to **21.2% for August 2026** (Fig 8). Consequently:
- **2024 vs 2025** medians are fully observed and unbiased.
- **2026 medians are censored (understated)**; where a 2026 figure looks bad, the true value is worse.

Every agency/time claim below states which of these it is. Per-capita rates use 2020 Census borough populations (the PRD's R5 caveat: lagged, directional not exact). No causal claims are made; findings are labeled **Observation / Interpretation / Hypothesis**.

Key Findings

Problems Getting Worse

1. The winter heat crisis is compounding (real trend, not seasonality).

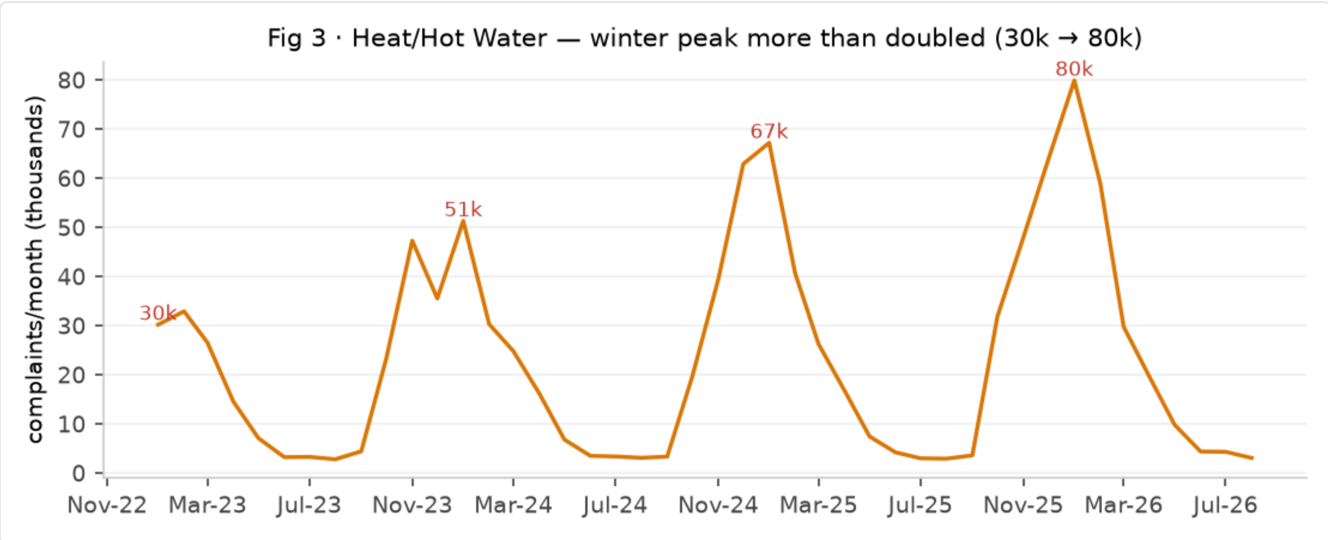

Fig 3 · Heat/Hot Water complaints by month. Winter peaks: 30k (2023) → 51k (2024) → 67k (2025) → 80k (2026).

- **Observation:** Heat/Hot Water is the #3 category overall (1.02M in the window). It is strongly seasonal, but the winter peak rose every year: **Jan 30,210 → 51,325 → 67,229 → 79,928** (2023→2026, **+165%** over the window); February followed the same path (32,929 → 59,031). Full-year 2024→2025 was **+19.3%**.
- **Calculation:** monthly complaint volume, compared at the same calendar month across years (Fig 3).
- **Interpretation:** this is a genuine, compounding problem — more units without heat each winter — not a change in reporting (channel mix is stable).
- **Alternative explanation:** a colder winter in 2025/26 could inflate the most recent peak. But the rise is monotonic across four years, which a single cold snap does not explain. **Hypothesis:** aging/under-heated housing stock, worsened by fuel-cost pressure.
- **Caveat:** volume ≠ severity; 311 cannot measure how cold or how long.

2. Residential noise and sanitation are growing at scale.

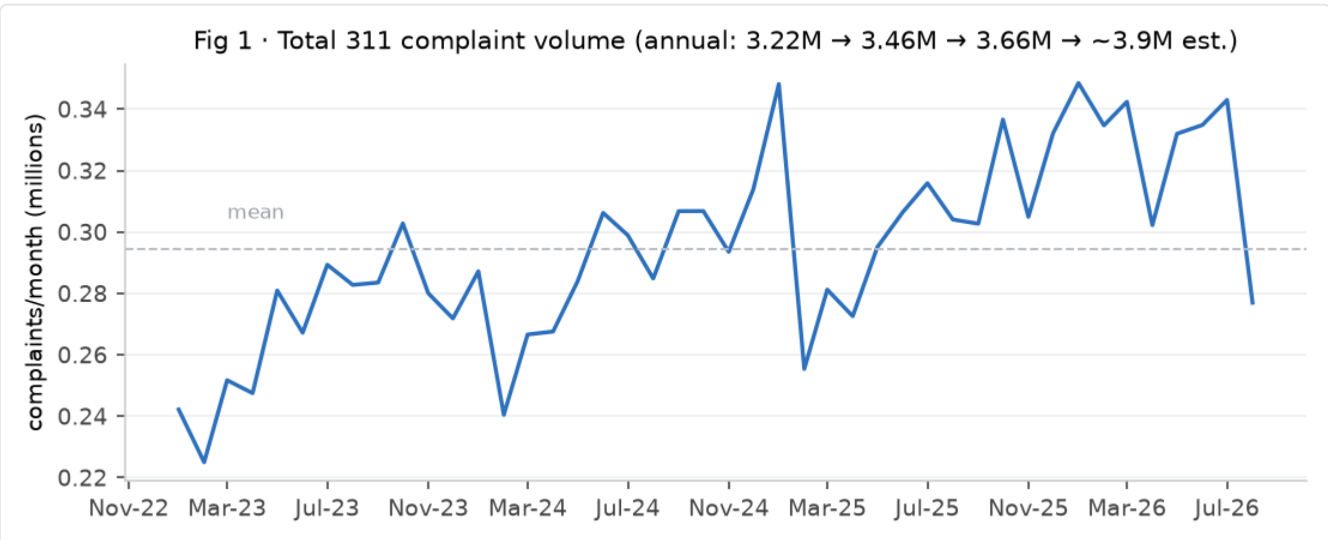

Fig 1 · Total monthly complaint volume, Jan 2023–Aug 2026. Annual: 3.22M → 3.46M → 3.66M → ~3.9M est.

- **Observation:** full-year 2024→2025: **Noise-Residential 379,296→463,349 (+22.2%)**; **Missed Collection 32,936→42,977 (+30.5%)**; **Residential Disposal Complaint 12,005→16,392 (+36.5%)**; **Water System 65,785→77,498 (+17.8%)**. Seasonally matched Jan–Aug 2026: **Water Leak +29.7%**, **Plumbing +27.8%**.
- **Interpretation:** the largest category (#2, Noise-Residential) is growing on the order of a quarter per year, and sanitation/infrastructure categories are rising together. **Hypothesis:** a densifying city plus aging water and refuse infrastructure.
- **Caveat:** these are the categories where "reporting fatigue" could cut the other way (understate), since people may stop reporting chronic problems — so growth here is likely a lower bound.

3. Damaged trees and storm-related damage are up sharply.
- **Observation: Damaged Tree +60.1%** (19,794→31,689, Jan–Aug 2026 vs 2025); Overgrown Tree/Branches +22.6%. Damaged Tree's summer 2026 months (Jun 7,592; Jul 7,989) are far above any prior year.
- **Interpretation:** consistent with increased severe-weather damage. **Hypothesis:** a series of storms; tree canopy pressure.
- **Caveat:** seasonal, so the matched window matters; 2026 is genuinely higher than 2025 at the same months.

Problems Improving

4. Several nuisance and policy-linked categories are declining sharply.

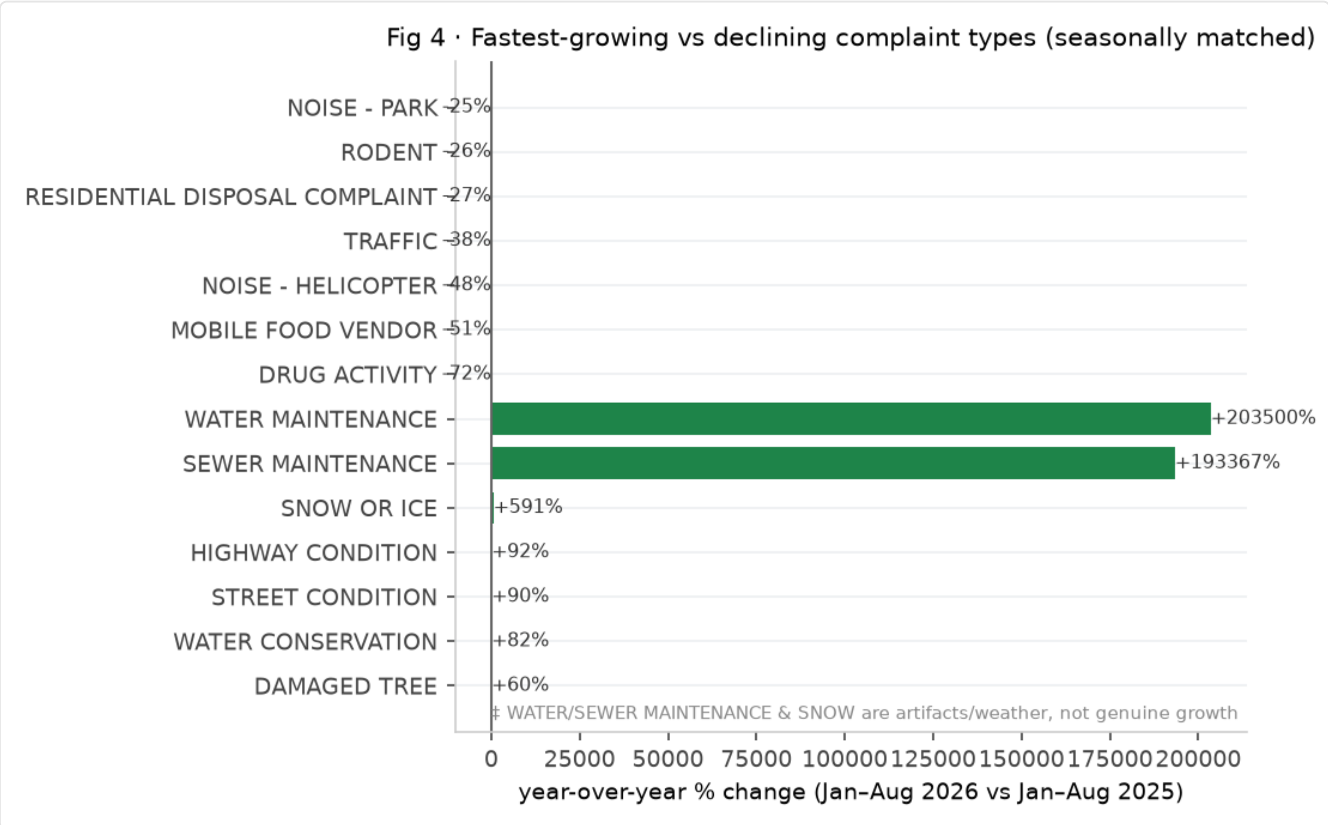

Fig 4 · Fastest-growing vs declining complaint types, seasonally matched (Jan–Aug 2026 vs 2025). ‡ Water/Sewer Maintenance and Snow are artifacts/weather.

- **Observation (seasonally matched, Jan–Aug 2026 vs 2025): Drug Activity −72.4%** (22,840→6,313); **Mobile Food Vendor −51.2%**; **Noise-Helicopter −47.5%** (13,257→6,963); **Traffic −37.7%**; **Rodent −26.5%**; **Missed Collection −25.1%**; **Lead −24.1%**; **Vendor Enforcement −22.5%**; **Derelict Vehicles −21.4%**.
- **Full-year 2024→2025 declines: Outdoor Dining −36.2%** (6,180→3,942); **New Tree Request −96.3%** (21,010→785).
- **Interpretation:** several are plausible policy effects — Outdoor Dining's rollback and Mobile Food Vendor enforcement are consistent with NYC's 2025 dining-program contraction. **Hypothesis:** New Tree Request's collapse reflects a **program/process change** (planting requests no longer routed through 311), not a sudden loss of interest in trees.

- **Caveat: Drug Activity's −72% must be read carefully** — it follows a sharp summer-2025 spike (6,038 in Jul, 5,447 in Aug 2025) and is 76% concentrated in Queens. **Hypothesis:** a targeted enforcement operation or a reporting-program change, not evidence that street-level drug activity itself vanished. Do not cite as a public-safety win without corroboration.

5. Fireworks and heat are stable seasonality, not worsening trends.
- **Observation:** ILLEGAL FIREWORKS July counts are essentially flat across years: **6,251 / 7,026 / 7,305 / 6,923** (2023–2026). SNOW OR ICE spikes are purely weather-driven (2026 Jan 24,079 / Feb 30,943 vs near-zero most other months).
- **Interpretation:** neither is a structural worsening; both are healthy "seasonal control" comparisons demonstrating the method.

Geographic Hotspots

6. The Bronx is the standout: highest per-capita load and the fastest-growing rate.

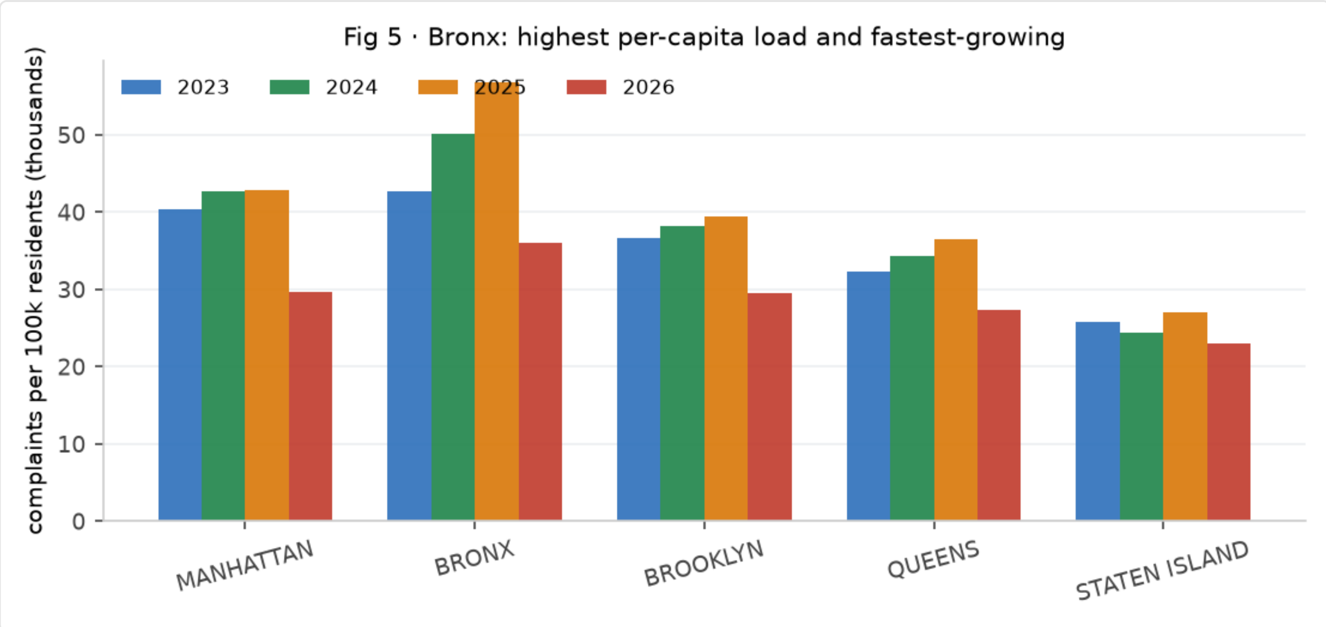

Fig 5 · Complaints per 100k residents by borough and year. The Bronx is highest and fastest-growing.

- **Observation:** whole-window complaints per 100k residents: **Bronx 185,575 (1.30× avg), Manhattan 155,510 (1.09×), Brooklyn 143,769 (1.00×), Queens 130,467 (0.91×), Staten Island 100,343 (0.70×)**. The Bronx's per-capita rate **rose +33%** from 2023→2025 (42,629→56,804) while Manhattan rose only +6% (Fig 5).
- **Interpretation:** a small share of the city carries a disproportionate and *growing* service load. **Hypothesis:** a compounding combination of housing-stock age, density, and service gaps.
- **Caveat:** per-capita uses 2020 populations; if the Bronx population shrank relatively, the rise is partly a denominator effect. Still, the magnitude (1.30×, widening) is robust.

7. Problem types are sharply geographically concentrated.
- **Observation: Encampment 70.2% in Manhattan** (155,106 total); **Homeless Person Assistance 63.6% Manhattan** (137,874); **Drug Activity 76.5% in Queens** (76,734); **Noise-Helicopter 56.7% Manhattan** (115,321); Lost Property 77.3% Manhattan; For-Hire-Vehicle 61.5% Manhattan.
- **Interpretation:** homelessness-adjacent and helicopter-noise problems are overwhelmingly a Manhattan phenomenon; drug-related complaints are a Queens phenomenon. Operations should be targeted, not city-wide.
- **Caveat:** concentration reflects where complaints are *reported*, which correlates with but is not identical to where conditions exist.

Agency Performance

Method note: Fig 6 compares 2024 vs 2025 (both fully observed → unbiased). 2026 figures are censored-low. Median response hours over closed complaints created Jan–Aug.

| Agency | 2024 | 2025 | 2026 (censored↓) | Read |

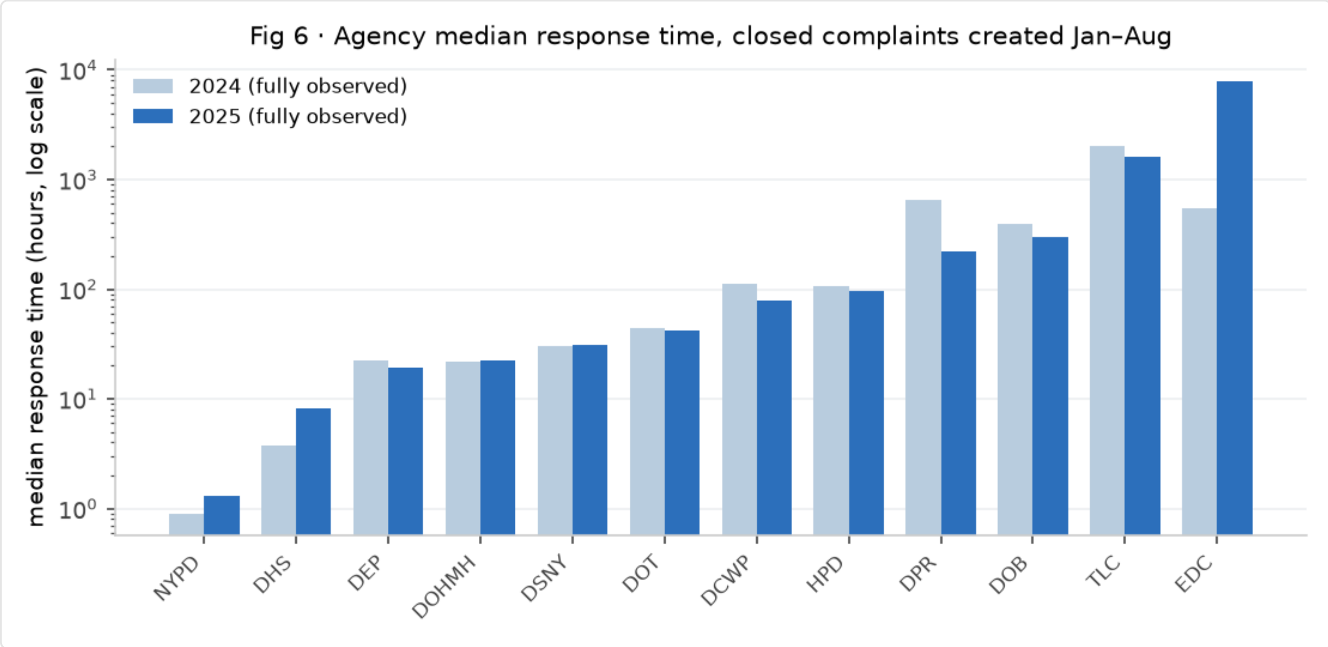

Fig 6 · Agency median response time (hours, log scale), closed complaints created Jan–Aug, 2024 vs 2025 (both fully observed).

NYPD	0.9	1.3	1.4	Still fastest; creeping slower (+56% over window)
DHS	3.8	8.1	7.0	Slower in 2025
DEP	22.4	19.2	18.9	Improving
DOHMH	22.0	22.1	**175.7** (17% open)	**2026 collapse**; true value worse
DOT	43.6	42.3	43.6	Stable
DSNY	30.0	31.3	36.4	Slowly worsening
HPD	106.3	95.4	102.5	~Flat; slight 2024–25 gain
DCWP	111.9	79.7	**411.4** (10% open)	Improved '24–'25, **collapsed 2026**
DOB	393.2	298.1	78.7	**Improving** (large)
DPR	649.9	220.4	81.1 (39% open)	**Improving** (large)
TLC	2005	1625	115.8 (66% open)	Still very slow (inspections)
DOE	549	1649	24 (tiny n)	Noisy/seasonal; not meaningful
EDC	541	**7,891**	— (100% open)	**Effectively stopped responding**

8. EDC has effectively abandoned complaint response.
- **Observation:** EDC's median response rose **541h → 7,891h** from 2024 to 2025, and in 2026 **100% of EDC complaints created in Jan–Aug are still open** (median undefined).
- **Interpretation:** an agency whose service request line is not being worked. **Hypothesis:** staffing/reassignment or a pipeline that stopped processing. **Recommendation:** confirm with the agency; EDC handles few complaints (n≈13k) but a 100%-open signal is unambiguous.

9. DOHMH and DCWP response collapsed in 2026 (and are worse than the numbers show).
- **Observation:** DOHMH median response was stable ~22h across 2024–25, then **175.7h in Jan–Aug 2026** — despite 17% of its recent complaints still open (so the true median is higher). DCWP fell from an improved 79.7h (2025) to **411.4h** in 2026 (10% open). Type-level: **Boilers +674%** (131→1,015h) and **Bridge Condition +469%** (116→663h) response slowdowns sit under DOB/DOT.
- **Interpretation:** these are 2026-specific degradations, not long-run trends — the 2024–25 data were healthy. **Hypothesis:** a 2026 capacity/backlog shock (seasonal, hiring, or inspection-pipeline changes).
- **Caveat:** censoring means the true 2026 medians are higher than stated.

10. Some agencies improved materially.
- **Observation:** DOB 393→298→79h; DPR 650→220→81h; DCWP 112→80h (2024–25). Damaged Tree and Elevator response also improved despite rising volume (Fig 7).
- **Interpretation:** where demand rose, DOB/DPR still got *faster* — evidence that response capability is an agency-specific choice, not a city-wide constraint.

Complaint Volume vs. Resolution Performance

11. The "double-bad" quadrant: volume up AND response worse.

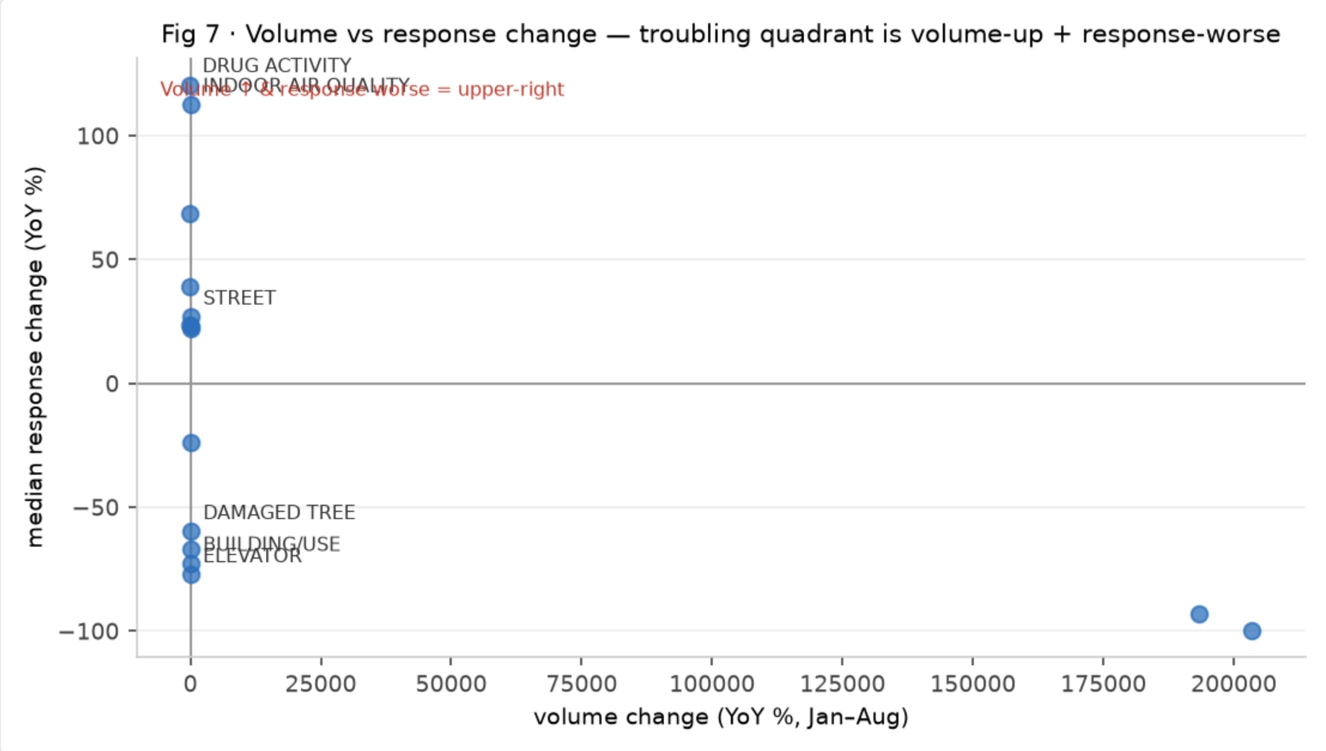

Fig 7 · Volume change vs response-time change by type (Jan–Aug 2026 vs 2025). The troubling quadrant is volume-up + response-worse (upper right).

- **Observation (Jan–Aug 2026 vs 2025): Street Condition** vol **+90%** AND resp **+27%** (25.6→32.5h); **Indoor Air Quality** vol +30% AND resp **+113%** (15→32h); **Traffic Signal Condition** vol +25% AND resp +22%.
- **Interpretation:** these are the complaints where the system is being hit from both sides. For Street Condition, volume is inflated by the reporting artifact (Finding 12), but the *response* worsening is real and independent.
- **Caveat:** 2026 response medians are censored-low, so the response worsening is understated.

12. Counterintuitive: response worse even where demand collapsed.

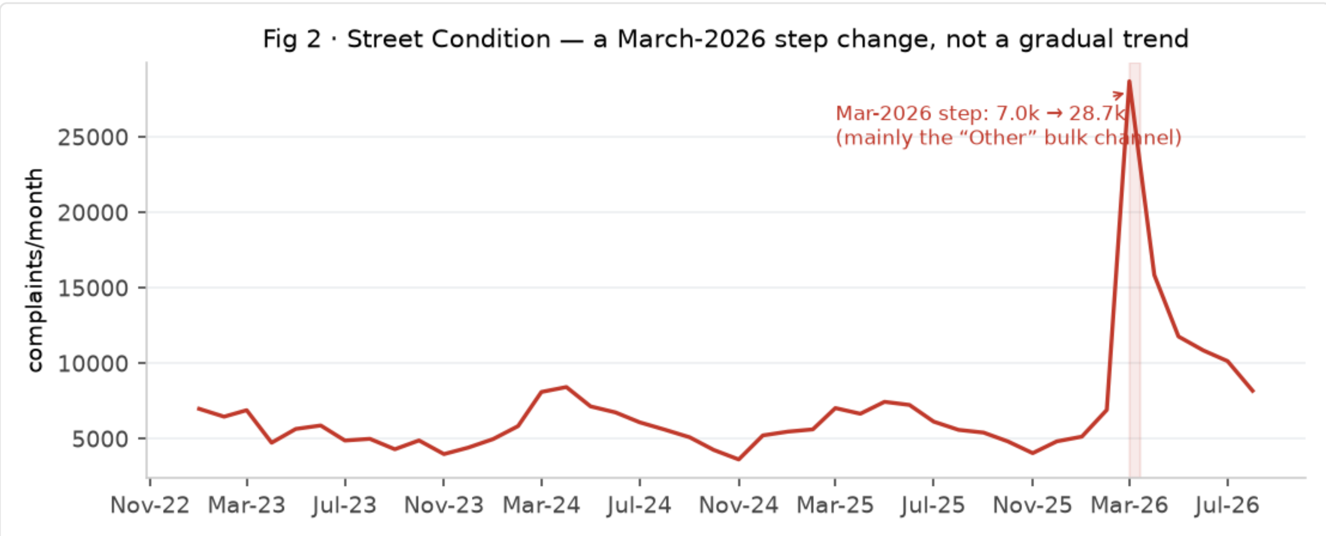

Fig 2 · Street Condition monthly volume. A single March-2026 step change (7.0k → 28.7k), driven by the "Other" bulk channel — a reporting artifact, not a gradual trend.

- **Observation: Drug Activity** vol **−72%** yet resp **+121%** (0.5→1.0h); **Traffic** vol −38% yet resp +69%; **Noise-Park** −25% yet resp +39%; **Residential Disposal** −27% yet resp +24%.

- **Interpretation:** falling demand did not free up response capacity for these — a sign the slowdown is structural (pipeline/process), not demand-driven.
- **Caveat:** NYPD-adjacent types remain fast in absolute terms (sub-2h); the *relative* worsening is what is notable.

13. Healthy cases: rising volume, faster response.
- **Observation: Damaged Tree** vol +60%, resp −60% (142→57h); **Elevator** +25%, −77% (396→90h); **Overgrown Tree** +23%, −67%; **Building/Use** +33%, −73% (1,709→467h).
- **Interpretation:** these show the system can scale response when managed well — the comparator that makes the worsening cases (Findings 8–9) look like choices, not inevitabilities.

Surprising Findings

- **The city's biggest "trend" is partly a data artifact.** Street Condition (+90% YoY) is a March-2026 step-change via the "Other" (bulk) channel — likely an institutional feed, not citizens. Any dashboard that flags it as a top worsening is being fooled by a schema/ingestion event.
- **Agencies can get slower as volume falls.** HPD-style "less demand, slower response" appears in Drug Activity, Traffic, and Noise-Park — the opposite of a capacity model.
- **The Bronx is both the most-burdened and fastest-worsening borough on a per-capita basis**, while the most media-covered homelessness problem is overwhelmingly Manhattan.
- **EDC's 100%-open backlog** is the single starkest agency signal in the dataset — an agency whose request line appears to have stopped working.

Data Quality and Limitations

1. **Left-censoring (most important).** Open complaints are excluded from response-time medians. % open rises from ~0.4–2% (2023–25) to **21.2% in Aug 2026**, so 2026 response figures are understated. All 2026 medians should be read as lower bounds.
2. **Category introductions are real. Sewer Maintenance** and **Water Maintenance** jumped from ~0–5/month (2023–2025) to **4,341** and **7,955** in Aug 2026 respectively. These are new taxonomy categories, not maintenance explosions; the app's E1/E2 classifier over-flags them because it cannot see the 3-year near-zero baseline. Any E2 on a type with a near-zero earlier baseline should be re-verified.
3. **Channel-dependent reporting.** Street Condition's 2026 surge is concentrated in the "Other" channel (bulk/systematic reporting), distinct from a digital-reporting-bias (which would show Mobile/Web share rising — it did not).
4. **Program/schema changes.** New Tree Request's −96% and Drug Activity's −72% likely reflect process/program changes, not the phenomena they name.
5. **Seasonality vs trend.** Now controlled via matched Jan–Aug windows; but full-year 2026 is incomplete (data ends Aug), so 2026 figures are Jan–Aug only.
6. **Per-capita denominators** are 2020 Census (lagged); rates are directional.
7. **Severity is unmeasured.** 311 volume is not weighted by urgency or hazard. Volume ≠ harm.
8. **Missing/unspecified geography** is negligible (a small share of rows), and is bucketed as UNSPECIFIED rather than dropped.

Recommendations for Further Investigation

1. **Resolve the Street Condition +90% artifact** — confirm with DSNY/DOT whether an institutional feed or new intake channel explains the March-2026 step; until then, do not report it as a real worsening.
2. **Audit the EDC 100%-open backlog** — confirm whether it is a data/API issue or a genuine cessation of response; this is the strongest single anomaly.
3. **DOHMH/DCWP 2026 degradation** — isolate the driver (seasonal inspection backlog, staffing, or pipeline change); because 2024–25 were healthy, this is a recent, addressable regression.
4. **Bronx operations** — investigate the widening per-capita gap (1.30×, +33% growth) and whether it reflects housing-stock age, response gaps, or differential reporting.
5. **Heat/Hot Water winter escalation** — the compounding Jan peak (30k→80k) warrants targeted landlord/fuel enforcement before next winter.

6. **Confirm Drug Activity's −72%** is a program change, not a real reduction, before any operational decisions hinge on it.
7. **Add a full year of 2025–26 data** once available to convert the Jan–Aug matched comparisons into complete-year YoY and to seasonally decompose each top category.

Appendix: Metric Definitions

- **Volume:** count of complaints by `created_date` month.
- **Per-capita rate:** `complaints / 2020 Census borough population × 100,000`.
- **Response time:** `first response time − created date` (hours), median over **closed** complaints in window.
- **Left-censoring:** open complaints excluded from response-time medians; share open by month reported so recent medians are not misread.
- **Seasonally matched YoY:** same calendar months compared across years (e.g., Jan–Aug 2026 vs Jan–Aug 2025) to neutralize seasonal effects.
- **E-classification (app taxonomy):** E1 = reporting/activity increase (volume up, rate flat, or channel shift); E2 = genuine worsening (rate up sustained, no channel explanation); E3 = worsening response performance. Used with caution given the category-introduction caveat in §Data Quality.
- **Reporting channel:** `channel_type` (Web/Mobile/Phone/Other). "Other" can denote bulk/systematic (non-resident) reporting.